

AP SPANISH LANGUAGE & CULTURE · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Apuntando a un 3, 4, o 5 — every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 6 THEMES · 3 MODES · EXAM ANATOMY

About this exam. AP Spanish is unlike any other AP exam. There are NO units of content to memorize — instead you're tested on **proficiency** (your ability to interpret, communicate, and produce Spanish across **3 modes**) themed around **6 contexts**. The single most important factor for scoring 4 or 5 is **using high-level Spanish in YOUR responses** — subjunctive, varied vocabulary, transitional phrases, complex sentences.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	MCQ (65q, 50%)	Free Response (4 tasks, 50%)	Approx %	Tier
3 (PASS)	~33 / 65 (~50%)	~3.0 avg / 5 per task	~46-52%	[3]
4	~42 / 65 (~65%)	~3.7 avg / 5 per task	~58-65%	[3] + [4]
5	~52 / 65 (~80%)	~4.3-4.5 avg / 5 per task	~75-82%	All

Time: 95 min for MCQ (~30 q reading, ~35 q listening). ~85 min for FRs: Email Reply (15 min) + Argumentative Essay (~55 min) + Conversation (5 min) + Cultural Comparison (~6 min). **Tasks 2-4 are recorded — you speak/write under time pressure.**

THE 6 THEMES (CONTEXTS) [3]

Theme	What it covers
1. La belleza estética	Beauty + aesthetics: art, music, literature, defining beauty across cultures
2. La ciencia y la tecnología	Science, tech, ethics, communication, environment
3. Las identidades personales y públicas	Personal/public identity, nationalism, heroes, gender roles
4. La vida contemporánea	Modern life: education, careers, leisure, travel, food
5. Los desafíos mundiales	Global challenges: poverty, conflict, environment, health, migration
6. Las familias y las comunidades	Family, customs, traditions, citizenship, community

KEY INSIGHT [4] Don't memorize themes — recognize them in passages. Every reading/listening/FRQ stimulus connects to ONE theme. Knowing the theme helps you anticipate vocabulary + cultural angles.

THE 3 MODES OF COMMUNICATION [3]/[4]

Mode	What you do
Interpretive [3]	Read, listen, watch (one-way, no response). MCQ section is mostly interpretive.
Interpersonal [3] / [4]	Two-way exchange — Email Reply (written) + Conversation (spoken).
Presentational [4] / [5]	Produce extended Spanish for an audience — Argumentative Essay (written) + Cultural Comparison (spoken).

PAGE 2 | EXAM ANATOMY — SECTION-BY-SECTION**SECTION I: MULTIPLE CHOICE (~95 min, 50% of score) [3]/[4]**

Part A: Reading (~40 min, 30 questions) — 4-5 passages: ad/email/article/literary text. Some are paired (interpretive across two related sources).

Part B: Reading + Listening (~55 min, 35 questions) — passages combined with audio (interview, lecture, podcast). Then audio-only segments.

Section I MCQ Strategy [3]/[4]/[5]

- [3] **Read the questions FIRST**, then the passage. Knowing what to look for cuts time hugely.
- [3] **Skim text/audio for KEY WORDS** that match question wording. Don't translate every word.
- [4] **On audio, take fast notes during the FIRST listen** (you get TWO listens for most). Names, numbers, opinions, conclusions.
- [4] **"Vocabulary in context" Q's**: substitute the answer choices in. The grammatical-fit + sense-fit one wins.
- [5] **Cultural questions**: pick the answer that's MOST nuanced + true across the Spanish-speaking world. Avoid stereotype answers.

SECTION II: FREE RESPONSE (~85 min, 50% of score)

#	Task	Time	What you do
1	Email Reply (interpersonal writing)	15 min	Read incoming email; write a reply addressing all questions + asking 1+ of your own. ~125-150 words.
2	Argumentative Essay (presentational writing)	~55 min	Read article + chart + listen to audio (3 sources). 40-min essay defending a thesis using ALL 3 sources.
3	Conversation (interpersonal speaking)	~5 min	5 prompts, 20 sec response each. Read outline first, then conversation begins. Recorded.
4	Cultural Comparison (presentational speaking)	~6 min	Read prompt (4 min prep) → 2-min spoken comparison between US + Spanish-speaking community on a cultural topic.

FRQ Scoring — the 5-point rubric (used for all 4 tasks) [3]/[4]/[5]

Each task scored 0-5 on:

1. Task completion (did you address EVERY part?)
2. Topic development (depth + specificity + cultural content)
3. Language use (grammar, vocabulary, fluency)

Score guides:

- | | | |
|-----|------------------------------|--|
| 5 = | STRONG | varied vocab, complex grammar, mostly accurate |
| 4 = | GOOD | generally accurate, some errors don't impede |
| 3 = | ADEQUATE | simple but functional, errors sometimes impede |
| 2 = | WEAK | basic, frequent errors |
| 1 = | POOR | |
| 0 = | off-topic, blank, or English | |

PAGE 3 | VERB CONJUGATION — TENSES & MOOD MATRIX

You can't score above 3 without strong verbs. Memorize the patterns; recognize the irregulars; use varied tenses to demonstrate control.

PRESENT INDICATIVE — regular [3]

-AR (hablar): hablo, hablas, habla, hablamos, habláis, hablan
 -ER (comer): como, comes, come, comemos, coméis, comen
 -IR (vivir): vivo, vives, vive, vivimos, vivís, viven

STEM-CHANGING (e→ie, o→ue, e→i) – change in all but nosotros/vosotros:

pensar: pienso, piensas, piensa, pensamos, pensáis, piensan
 poder: puedo, puedes, puede, podemos, podéis, pueden
 pedir: pido, pides, pide, pedimos, pedís, piden

PRETERITE vs IMPERFECT — the past-tense decision [3]/[4]

Use	When
PRETERITE [3]	Completed action , specific moment, clear beginning/end. " <i>Comí pizza ayer.</i> " " <i>La fiesta empezó a las 8.</i> "
IMPERFECT [3]	Background, ongoing, repeated. Time, age, weather, descriptions. " <i>Cuando era niño, jugaba al fútbol.</i> "
Both [4]	<i>Mientras yo cocinaba (imperfect, ongoing), sonó (preterite, interruption) el teléfono.</i>

PRETERITE Irregulars — must memorize [3]/[4]

ser/ir (same!): fui, fuiste, fue, fuimos, fuisteis, fueron
 ver: vi, viste, vio, vimos, visteis, vieron
 hacer: hice, hiciste, hizo, hicimos, hicisteis, hicieron
 tener: tuve, tuviste, tuvo, tuvimos, tuvisteis, tuvieron
 estar: estuve, estuviste, estuvo, estuvimos, ...
 poder: pude, pudiste, pudo, pudimos, ...
 poner: puse, pusiste, puso, ...
 decir: dije, dijiste, dijo, dijimos, dijisteis, dijeron (no -i in 3rd pl)
 traer: traje, ... trajeron
 saber: supe, supiste, supo, ...

Other essential tenses [3]/[4]/[5]

FUTURE [3]: hablaré, hablarás, hablará, hablaremos, hablaréis, hablarán
 CONDITIONAL [4]: hablaría, hablarías, hablaría, hablaríamos, hablaríais, hablarían

 PRESENT PERFECT [3]: he/has/ha/hemos/habéis/han + PARTICIPLE
 hablado, comido, vivido | hecho (hacer), dicho (decir), visto (ver),
 abierto (abrir), escrito (escribir), puesto (poner), vuelto (volver)

 PAST PERFECT [4]: había/habías/había/habíamos/habíais/habían + PARTICIPLE
 CONDITIONAL PERFECT [5]: habría + PARTICIPLE

 PROGRESSIVE [3]: estoy hablando / estaba comiendo / etc.

PAGE 4 | SER vs ESTAR · POR vs PARA · KEY DISTINCTIONS**SER vs ESTAR [3]/[4]**

SER = permanent, identity, characteristics ("DOCTOR":
Date/time, Origin, Characteristics, Time-of-day, Occupation, Relationships)

ESTAR = temporary, location, condition, feeling ("PLACE":
Position, Location, Action (in -ndo), Condition, Emotion)

EXAMPLES:

Soy alta. (I am tall – characteristic)
Estoy cansada. (I am tired – temporary state)
Soy de México. (I'm from Mexico – origin)
Estoy en casa. (I'm at home – location)
Es las dos. (It's two o'clock – time)
Estoy escribiendo. (I'm writing – progressive)

Meaning changes with SER vs ESTAR [4]/[5]

Adjective	with SER	with ESTAR
aburrido	boring ("He is a boring person")	bored ("I am bored")
listo	clever, smart	ready
rico	rich (wealthy)	tasty (food)
malo	bad (evil)	sick
verde	green (color)	unripe
callado	quiet by nature	silent (right now)

POR vs PARA [3]/[4]/[5]

POR – "by/through/because of/for (duration/exchange)"
cause/reason: Lo hizo POR amor.
duration: Estudié POR dos horas.
movement THROUGH: Caminamos POR el parque.
exchange: Te doy 5 dólares POR el libro.
means/by: Hablé POR teléfono.
on behalf of: Voté POR ti.

PARA – "for/to/in order to/destination/deadline"
purpose/goal: Estudio PARA aprender.
recipient: El regalo es PARA Maria.
destination: Salgo PARA Madrid mañana.
deadline: La tarea es PARA el lunes.
employer: Trabajo PARA Google.
opinion: PARA mí, esto es importante.

KEY INSIGHT [4] When in doubt, ask: am I describing the WAY/REASON something is done (POR), or the GOAL/RECIPIENT (PARA)? "Camino para el parque" = walking TO the park (destination). "Camino por el parque" = walking THROUGH the park.

Direct + Indirect Object Pronouns [3]/[4]

DIRECT (DOP): me, te, lo/la, nos, os, los/las ("who/what got verbed")
INDIRECT (IOP): me, te, le, nos, os, les ("to/for whom")

ORDER: IOP + DOP + verb
Me lo dio. (He gave it to me.)

le/les + lo/la/los/las → becomes SE + lo/la/los/las
Le di el libro a Juan → Se lo di. (NOT *Le lo di.)

PAGE 5 | SUBJUNCTIVE — THE 4-TO-5 BARRIER

Want a 4 or 5? Master subjunctive. It signals advanced control. Graders specifically reward correct subjunctive usage. **Most students at the 3-level avoid it; 4-5 students use it confidently.**

Present Subjunctive Forms [4]/[5]

RULE: take 'yo' form of present indicative, drop -o, add **OPPOSITE** endings:
 -AR verbs use -e endings: hable, hables, hable, hablemos, habléis, hablen
 -ER/-IR verbs use -a endings: coma, comas, coma, comamos, comáis, coman

IRREGULAR (memorize): "DISHES"

Dar: dé, des, dé, demos, deis, den
 Ir: vaya, vayas, vaya, vayamos, vayáis, vayan
 Ser: sea, seas, sea, seamos, seáis, sean
 Haber: haya, hayas, haya, hayamos, hayáis, hayan
 Estar: esté, estés, esté, estemos, estéis, estén
 Saber: sepa, sepa, sepa, sepamos, sepáis, sepan

WHEN to use subjunctive — "WEIRDO" [4]/[5]

W – Wishes/Will:	Espero que vengas.	Quiero que estudies.
E – Emotion:	Me alegra que estés aquí.	Es triste que se vaya.
I – Impersonal expression:	Es importante que sepas.	Es necesario que vayas.
R – Recommendation:	Recomiendo que tomes agua.	Sugiero que descanses.
D – Doubt/Denial:	Dudo que sea verdad.	No creo que esté listo.
O – Ojalá:	Ojalá que llueva mañana.	

TRIGGER PATTERN: [trigger verb] + QUE + [subjunctive verb]

Conjunctions that ALWAYS trigger subjunctive [4]/[5]

para que	(so that)
a menos que	(unless)
antes (de) que	(before)
con tal (de) que	(provided that)
sin que	(without)
en caso de que	(in case)

TIME conjunctions take subjunctive ONLY for FUTURE/UNCERTAIN events:
 cuando, hasta que, en cuanto, tan pronto como, después (de) que
 Cuando llegue (subjunctive – not yet happened) → vs.
 Cuando llegó (preterite – completed past).

Imperfect Subjunctive [5]

Take 3rd-person plural preterite, drop -ron, add: -ra, -ras, -ra, -rámos, -rais, -ran
 hablaron → hablara, hablaras, hablara, habláramos, hablarais, hablaran

USES:

Past triggers (Quería que ESTUDIARAS más.)
 Hypothetical "if" clauses with conditional (Si TUVIERA dinero, viajaría.)
 "Como si" + imperfect subjunctive (Habla como si supiera.)

KEY INSIGHT [5] Quick subjunctive sentence to drop in essays. "Es importante que ****tomemos**** medidas para resolver este problema." or "Si ****tuvieramos**** más recursos, podríamos hacer más." Both signal advanced grammar to graders.

PAGE 6 | FRQ TASKS 1-2: EMAIL REPLY · ARGUMENTATIVE ESSAY**TASK 1: EMAIL REPLY (15 min, written) [3]/[4]/[5]**

You receive a formal email; reply addressing every question + asking a follow-up. ~125-150 words. Use formal register ("usted").

RECIPE FOR A 5/5:

1. FORMAL GREETING: Estimado/a [Sr./Sra.] [Nombre]:
2. THANKING + acknowledgment: Le agradezco mucho su mensaje sobre...
3. ANSWER EVERY QUESTION asked – be specific.
4. ASK 1+ ORIGINAL QUESTION (required! Often missed → -1 point).
5. FORMAL CLOSING: Atentamente, / Cordialmente, / Le saluda atentamente,
[Your name]

FORMAL REGISTER: USE USTED + corresponding verb forms (3rd person sing.)
"¿Podría usted enviarme...?" NOT "¿Puedes enviarme...?"

WATCH OUT [4] Most-missed point on Email Reply: forgetting to ASK A QUESTION. Even if it's brief — "¿Podría darme más información sobre [X]?" — write one.

TASK 2: ARGUMENTATIVE ESSAY (~55 min total) [4]/[5]

The biggest single task on the exam. You read article, examine chart/graph, listen to audio (twice). Then 40 minutes to write argumentative essay defending a thesis using ALL 3 sources.

STRUCTURE (4-5 paragraphs):

- INTRO: Hook + thesis statement. Identify your position clearly.
 BODY 1: First argument + evidence from FUENTE 1 (article).
 BODY 2: Second argument + evidence from FUENTE 2 (graph/chart).
 BODY 3: Third argument + evidence from FUENTE 3 (audio).
 OR: counter-argument + rebuttal using a source.
 CONCLUSION: Restate thesis (different words) + call to action / final reflection.

CRITICAL: cite all 3 sources by name ("según la fuente 1...", "el gráfico muestra...", "en la fuente auditiva...") – NOT citing all 3 = automatic ceiling of 3.

Essay-writing power phrases [4]/[5]

THESIS / POSITION:

- En mi opinión... / Sostengo que... / Es evidente que...
 A mi parecer... / Considero que... / Estoy a favor / en contra de...

CITING SOURCES:

- Según la fuente 1... / El artículo destaca que...
 El gráfico muestra que... / La tabla indica que...
 En la fuente auditiva, [persona] menciona que...

TRANSITIONS:

- Por otro lado / Sin embargo / No obstante / A pesar de eso
 Además / Asimismo / Por consiguiente / En consecuencia
 Por ejemplo / Cabe destacar que / Es importante señalar...

CONCLUSION:

- En conclusión / Para concluir / En definitiva / Después de analizar...

PAGE 7 | FRQ TASKS 3-4: CONVERSATION · CULTURAL COMPARISON

TASK 3: CONVERSATION (~5 min, spoken) [3]/[4]/[5]

Read the conversation outline first (1 min prep). Then a recorded prompt plays; you have **20 seconds** to respond. **5 prompts total**. Use TÚ form (informal — usually a friend/peer).

20-SECOND RESPONSE FORMULA:

1. Acknowledge what was said (¡Qué buena idea! / Sí, claro. / Pues, mira...)
2. Answer / react (En mi opinión... / Lo que pasa es...)
3. Add detail or reason (porque... / por ejemplo...)
4. (If room) ask follow-up (¿y tú qué piensas? / ¿qué te parece si...?)

FILLER while thinking (use sparingly):

Mira... / Bueno... / A ver... / Pues... / Es decir... / O sea...

Conversation success habits [4]/[5]

- [3] **FILL THE 20 SECONDS**. Silence = lost points. Even repeating with extra detail beats stopping early.
- [3] **Match the tone of the prompt** — informal friend, joking, planning, etc.
- [4] **Use varied vocabulary**, not the same 5 words every prompt. "*creo, pienso, opino, me parece, considero*" — rotate.
- [5] **Drop in a subjunctive at least once**. "*Espero que vengas.*" "*Sería bueno que...*"
- [5] **Use cultural specifics if natural** ("*Como dicen en México...*" or "*En la cultura hispana...*").

TASK 4: CULTURAL COMPARISON (~6 min total, spoken) [4]/[5]

Read the prompt (4 min prep). Then **2 minutes** to deliver an UNINTERRUPTED spoken comparison between your community/culture and a Spanish-speaking community/country. **This is the hardest task — and the highest 5-bar.**

RECIPE FOR A 5/5:

INTRO (15-20 sec):

"En esta presentación, compararé [topic] entre los Estados Unidos y [Mexico/España/Argentina/etc..]."

BODY 1 — US perspective (40 sec):

Specific examples, anecdotes, statistics. Be CONCRETE.

BODY 2 — Spanish-speaking perspective (40 sec):

MUST mention SPECIFIC country + concrete examples.

"Por ejemplo, en México, durante el Día de los Muertos..."

COMPARISON / CONTRAST (15-20 sec):

"Aunque ambas culturas..., una diferencia importante es..."

CONCLUSION (10 sec):

"En resumen, ambas comunidades... / Esta comparación muestra..."

KEY INSIGHT [5] Pre-load 4-5 "go-to" Spanish-speaking communities/countries with cultural specifics: Día de los Muertos (Mexico), tapas + sobremesa (Spain), tango (Argentina), arepas + carnaval (Colombia/Venezuela), siesta + paseo, telenovelas. **This way, no matter what the prompt asks, you have material.**

Cultural Comparison common topics [4]/[5]

- Family structure + role of grandparents (multigenerational vs nuclear).
- Education systems: high school, college access, career paths.
- Food + meal customs: when, what, with whom.
- Holidays + religious traditions (Día de los Muertos, Las Posadas, etc.).
- Gender roles + workplace participation.
- Government/social welfare differences.
- Use of public space — plazas, paseo, café culture.
- Music + popular arts (regional).

PAGE 8 | POWER PHRASES · CULTURAL VOCAB · IDIOMS

"5-Worthy" sophisticated phrases — drop in essays + speaking [4]/[5]

Cabe destacar que...	It's worth noting that...
Es preciso señalar...	It's necessary to point out...
No cabe duda de que...	There's no doubt that...
Vale la pena mencionar...	It's worth mentioning...
Por consiguiente...	Consequently...
Dicho esto...	Having said that...
En lo que se refiere a...	Regarding...
A pesar de que...	Despite...
Hoy en día...	Nowadays...
A largo / corto plazo...	In the long / short term...
Hace falta + INF	It's necessary to...
Llevar a cabo	to carry out (action)
Tener en cuenta que...	To bear in mind that...

Cultural-specific vocabulary by theme [4]/[5]

Theme	Useful vocabulary
Identity / family	el patrimonio (heritage), la herencia cultural, el orgullo, las costumbres, los antepasados, la patria
Tech + science	el avance, la red social, la pantalla, el ciberespacio, la innovación, la inteligencia artificial, el bienestar
Global challenges	la pobreza, la desigualdad, el calentamiento global, la migración, los refugiados, el desarrollo sostenible
Modern life	el ocio, el ritmo de vida, el estrés, la presión, el equilibrio, la salud mental
Beauty / arts	el patrimonio artístico, la obra maestra, el legado, el muralismo, el folclore, la cosmovisión
Family / community	los lazos familiares, la convivencia, la solidaridad, la unidad, el respeto, la herencia, el compromiso

Common idioms / sayings ("refranes") [5]

No hay mal que por bien no venga.	Every cloud has a silver lining.
Más vale tarde que nunca.	Better late than never.
Querer es poder.	Where there's a will, there's a way.
Más vale prevenir que lamentar.	Better safe than sorry.
De tal palo, tal astilla.	Like father, like son.
En boca cerrada no entran moscas.	Silence is golden.
Mejor solo que mal acompañado.	Better alone than in bad company.

KEY INSIGHT [5] Drop ONE refrán in your Cultural Comparison. It signals cultural fluency to graders. *"Como dice el refrán, querer es poder, y eso refleja la actitud de muchos jóvenes hispanos hacia la educación."*

PAGE 9 | TOP MISTAKES · GRADER PSYCHOLOGY · TIME STRATEGY

Mistakes that cap your score at 3 [3]/[4]

- [3] **Slipping into English** (or made-up Spanish words). Even one English word in a recorded response = lost points.
- [3] **Not addressing every part of the prompt** (Email Reply: missed question = -1; Cultural Comparison: missed comparison = -1).
- [3] **Long silences in spoken tasks**. Better to say something simple than be silent.
- [3] **Wrong register**: using TÚ in formal email or USTED in informal conversation. Read context before speaking/writing.
- [3] **Genus/number errors**: la problema (wrong; el problema), el agua (correct, but feminine adjectives: el agua fría).

Mistakes that cap your score at 4 [4]/[5]

- [4] **Avoiding subjunctive entirely**. Graders specifically look for subjunctive in 5-level work.
- [4] **Limited vocabulary** — same words repeated. Pre-load 30+ sophisticated words from Page 8.
- [4] **Citing only 1-2 sources in essay** instead of all 3.
- [4] **No specific country in Cultural Comparison** — just "in Spanish-speaking countries" generically. Always name a specific one + a specific tradition.
- [5] **No transition phrases** — paragraphs/responses feel disconnected. Use "además, por otro lado, sin embargo, en cambio."
- [5] **Errors in the BASIC tenses while showing off complex ones** — accuracy in present + preterite must be solid before reaching for past perfect subjunctive.

Time Management — exam-day strategy [3]/[4]

MCQ Reading (~40 min): ~80 sec / question. Tag hard ones; come back.

MCQ Listening (~55 min): notes during 1st listen, refine on 2nd.

Email Reply (15 min):

1 min — read email, identify all questions

11 min — write

3 min — proofread, check verb agreement, add the question if missing

Argumentative Essay (~55 min total):

~15 min — read article, examine graph, take notes

~10 min — listen twice + take notes

~5 min — outline (thesis + 3 source-based points)

~25 min — write

~5 min — proofread (verb tenses, source citations)

Cultural Comparison (~6 min):

4 min prep — pick country, list 3 specifics each side, comparison phrase

2 min speaking — DON'T STOP. Use prep notes as outline.

PAGE 10 | SCORE LADDER · TIER CHECKLISTS · THE ONE THING

THE SCORE LADDER

For a 3 (Pass)	For a 4	For a 5
MCQ: 33-38 / 65	MCQ: 42-48 / 65	MCQ: 52-58 / 65
Stick to present + simple past. No English.	Add: future + conditional + present perfect + subjunctive (basic).	Master subjunctive (present + imperfect), conditional perfect, complex transitions.
Email Reply: greet, answer, close.	Email + ASK A QUESTION + formal register throughout.	Email + sophisticated transitions + nuanced vocabulary.
Essay: cite 1-2 sources, basic structure.	Essay: cite ALL 3, clear thesis + 3 body paragraphs.	Essay: complex argument, counter-rebuttal, advanced grammar throughout.
Conversation: speak 15+ of 20 sec each.	Conversation: respond to nuance, use varied vocab.	Conversation: subjunctive, idioms, follow-up questions.
Cultural Comparison: name a country + 1 tradition.	Country + multiple specifics + 1 comparison.	Country + nuance + refrán + complex grammar.

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — focus only on these:

- ✓ MCQ: 33+ correct.
- ✓ NEVER use English. Approximate with simpler Spanish if you don't know a word.
- ✓ Address every question in Email Reply.
- ✓ Use present + preterite/imperfect accurately.
- ✓ Speak the full 20 sec on every conversation prompt.
- ✓ Cultural Comparison: NAME a specific country + at least 1 specific tradition.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 42+ correct.
- ✓ Use TÚ for friend, USTED for formal — match register.
- ✓ Email Reply: ASK A QUESTION.
- ✓ Essay: cite ALL 3 sources by name.
- ✓ Use present subjunctive at least once per task.
- ✓ 4+ different transition phrases per essay.

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 52+ correct.
- ✓ Imperfect subjunctive in essays + cultural comparison.
- ✓ Conditional + conditional perfect in hypothetical statements.
- ✓ Drop a refrán in cultural comparison.
- ✓ Counter-argument + rebuttal in argumentative essay.
- ✓ Sophisticated vocabulary from your pre-loaded bank.
- ✓ Self-correct gracefully if you make an error: "*quiero decir...*"

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: PRODUCE SPANISH ACCURATELY AND FLUENTLY. AP Spanish is a PROFICIENCY exam — graders aren't checking what you know about Spanish, they're checking if you can USE it. Speak/write more, not less. Use varied tenses including subjunctive. Cite sources by name. Name specific countries. Fill every speaking second. **The students who score 5 don't necessarily know more grammar — they USE more grammar in every response.** Confidence + production beats hesitation + perfection.

Si no haces nada más: domina el subjuntivo, cita tres fuentes, nunca uses inglés. ¡Tú puedes!

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